American Beech

Fagus grandifolia

Family: Not stated Also known as: —

GARDENS Orangerie: 4 **TOTAL 4**



Summer / form
Library candidate



Fall color
Library candidate

Not available

Flower
Not available



Leaf close-up
Library candidate

QUICK FACTS & PLANTING

Type: Tree
Evergreen/Deciduous: Deciduous
Mature size: 50–80 ft (sources range 50–70 ft to 50–80+ ft). **Open:** Mature height range varies; no tight three-source agreement for typical landscapes. × 40–80 ft. Confirmed range.
Hardiness / Zone 8a: Suitable for Zone 8a. Hardy Zones 3–9. Native to eastern North America including Georgia. Performs in Atlanta. Prefers moist, well-drained acidic soil. Does not tolerate compaction or wet soils. Slow growing. Shallow roots make underplanting difficult. Restart pass (2026-10-13): NC State confirms native range and moist well-drained preference. Existing notes stand.
Sun: Full sun to part shade.
Water: Medium. Prefers moist, well-drained soil. Not drought tolerant when young.
Soil: Moist, well-drained, acidic preferred. Intolerant of compaction, wet soils, or poor drainage.
Growth rate: Not stated
Not stated
Planting:
Siting: Plant in full sun to part shade in moist, well-drained, non-compacted soil. Water regularly until established. Avoid mechanical injury to roots and trunk. Difficult to grow grass underneath due to shallow roots. Minimal pruning. Suitable as large shade or specimen tree in appropriate sites.
Soil prep: Moist, well-drained, acidic preferred. Intolerant of compaction, wet soils, or poor drainage.
Depth/spacing: Not stated
Season: Not stated
Establishment: Not stated

ORIGIN, CHARACTERISTICS & HEALTH

Origin / native: Native to rich deciduous and mixed woodlands of eastern North America.
Form / habit: Deciduous. Large tree. Short trunk. Wide-spreading dense crown. Slow growth. Can sucker.
Foliage: Golden bronze to yellow. Leaves often persist into winter on younger growth.
Flowers / fruit: Not stated
Bark / stem: Smooth silvery-gray. Distinctive and retained into old age.
Not stated
Health:
Health notes: Possible issues: aphids, oystershell scale, leaf diseases. Beech bark disease and beech leaf disease are concerns in parts of the range. Shallow roots sensitive to disturbance. **Open:** Specific Zone 8a incidence of major diseases is thin.
Not stated
Additional:
- Smooth gray bark. - Parallel-veined leaves with teeth. - Edible beechnuts in prickly husks. - Long-lived (200+ years possible). - Winter-persistent leaves on young branches.